

Namibia



A former German colony that was dominated by South Africa until winning independence in 1990.

1890 An Anglo-German agreement acknowledges German control of South West Africa and Britain's annexation of Walvis Bay in 1886 for Cape Colony. German colonists take best farming land and displace the indigenous people.

1904–08 Germans ruthlessly suppress rising by the Hereros and Namaqua, killing about 80,000 in open genocide; a harsh forced-labor regime is introduced.

1915 German forces surrender to South African troops.

1920 League of Nations awards South Africa the mandate to administer the territory "as an integral part of the Union of South Africa." South Africa extends the German policy of reserves for the indigenous population, 17 of which are established by 1939.

1946 UN General Assembly rejects South African request to incorporate South West Africa into its own territory; South Africa refuses to agree a trusteeship agreement.

1950 International Court of Justice rules that South Africa has no right to change the international status of the territory. Two further ICJ rulings, in 1955 and 1956, uphold the UN's right to supervise the administration.

1960 South West Africa People's Organization (SWAPO) is formed under Sam Nujoma and Herman Toivo ja Toivo. Based on the Ovamboland People's Organization, formed earlier with the aim of ending the contract labor system, SWAPO has broader objectives; it seeks to mobilize all the people of Namibia against South African rule.

1966 Apartheid laws imposed: SWAPO begins armed struggle.

1968 Country is renamed Namibia by UN General Assembly.

1972 UN recognizes SWAPO.

1990 After concerted international pressure and years of armed struggle, Namibia gains independence from South Africa; Sam Nujoma is elected president.

1994 South Africa relinquishes Walvis Bay.

1999 Sam Nujoma wins third term.

2004 Hifikepunye Pohamba is president.

2005 Government begins expropriation of white-owned farms.

2009 President Pohamba is reelected.

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Botswana



An arid and landlocked country wealthy from diamonds and minerals but weakened by AIDS.

1813 The London Missionary Society establishes a mission, the first permanent settlements having been established by the Kwena (a Tswana people), who had come from South Africa a century earlier.

1885 The UK establishes the Bechuanaland Protectorate at request of local people to preempt annexation by South Africa.

1900 Administration passes to the High Commissioner for Basutoland, Bechuanaland, and Swaziland, with minimal interference in tribal affairs and only limited sales of land to white settlers and companies.

1920 Elected European and separate nominated African advisory councils are formed; the latter serves as a forum for African opposition to South African pressure for incorporation.

1948 Incorporation into South Africa is ruled out when the National Party comes to power there, but South Africa by now dominates the economy, which is little more than a labor reserve for South African mines and farms.

1950 As a result of South African pressure, tribal chief Seretse Khama is exiled by the UK administration following his marriage to a white Englishwoman. He is only allowed to return six years later on condition that he renounces the chieftainship of the Bamangwato.

1951 Joint advisory council is formed.

1961 Legislative council is set up.

1965 Bechuanaland (later Botswana) Democratic Party (BDP), led by Seretse Khama, wins first general election and all subsequent general elections.

1966 Independence declared.

1980 Vice President Quett (later Ketumile) Masire succeeds the late Seretse Khama as president.

1992–93 Strikes and corruption scandals prompt resignations of senior BDP figures.

1994 BDP support eroded in election.

1998 Vice President Festus Mogae succeeds Masire as president.

2001 Botswana has world's highest HIV infection rate of 38.3 percent of the population.

2008 BDP wins elections and Seretse Khama, son of the first president, is returned as president.

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Zimbabwe



A formerly rich country reduced to poverty and economic collapse by its long-serving dictator.

500s Bantu speakers migrate south into the country, displacing earlier iron-working cultures.

1400s Great Zimbabwe grows rich on cattle grazing, gold mining, and trade with merchants on the coast.

1830s Shona peoples displaced by incoming Ndebele invaders, who force them to pay tribute.

1890 British South Africa Company of Cecil Rhodes founds Fort Salisbury as settlers begin to colonize the country.

1896–97 Shona and Ndebele revolt unsuccessfully against British rule.

1911 Rhodesia divided into southern and northern halves.

1923 After settlers vote against joining South Africa, Southern Rhodesia becomes a self-governing British colony.

1953 Southern Rhodesia joins Northern Rhodesia (now Zambia) and Nyasaland (now Malawi) in the Federation of Rhodesia and Nyasaland.

1961 Joshua Nkomo forms Zimbabwe African People's Union (ZAPU).

1962 ZAPU banned. Segregationist Rhodesian Front (RF) wins elections.

1963 African nationalists in Northern Rhodesia and Nyasaland demand dissolution of federation, which



Great Zimbabwe

Ruins are all that remain of Great Zimbabwe, the city that lay at the heart of the vast Munhumatapa Empire (c.1450–1629), which once incorporated present-day Zimbabwe and Mozambique.

is then dissolved. Zimbabwe African National Union (ZANU) is formed by the Reverend Sithole and Robert Mugabe.

1964 New RF prime minister Ian Smith rejects British demands for majority rule.

1965 RF reelected: Ian Smith declares unilateral independence from the UK, which imposes economic sanctions. ZANU and ZAPU begin guerrilla war.

1976 ZANU and ZAPU unite as Patriotic Front (PF) and are backed by frontline African states of Mozambique, Tanzania, Botswana, and Zambia.

1979 After four years, talks at Lancaster House in London reach agreement on a new constitution for majority rule. Britain resumes colonial rule.

1980 Independence as Zimbabwe. After a violent election campaign, Mugabe becomes prime minister.

1983–84 Unrest in Matabeleland, ZAPU–PF's power base.

1985 Elections return ZANU–PF, with manifesto to create one-party state; many ZAPU–PF members arrested.

1987 ZAPU–PF banned. Provision for white seats in parliament abolished. ZANU–PF and ZAPU–PF sign unity agreement. Mugabe elected president, with Nkomo as vice-president.

1990 Elections won by ZANU–PF. Mugabe reelected president.

1998 Nationwide strikes and protests against Mugabe's authoritarian rule. The Opposition Movement for Democratic Change (MDC) is founded the following year.

2000 Expropriations of white-owned farms by squatters lead to collapse in food production and rising inflation.

2006 Economic situation worsens. Inflation exceeds 1,000 percent.

2007 Morgan Tsvangirai, head of the MDC, is severely beaten by police.

2008 In presidential elections, opposition leader Morgan Tsvangirai wins most votes in first round to face run-off with Robert Mugabe. Tsvangirai boycotts the second round, alleging intimidation and Mugabe is declared the winner. Subsequent negotiations between the two lead to a power-sharing agreement.

2009 Tsvangirai is sworn in as prime minister, but the relationship between him and Mugabe is troubled, with allegations of violence orchestrated by ZANU and violations of the constitution.

2010 Annual rate of inflation, which had reached 231 million percent in 2008, declines to 4.1 percent.

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